TARIQUE RAHMAN

THE LONG WALK TO PREMIERSHIP


AFP

A **photograph posted on Facebook** on February 18 captured a quiet but telling moment. Shared by an old friend of Tarique Rahman, it carried a Bengali caption that translated loosely to "peace of the eyes". In the image, Rahman—dressed in a crisp white shirt—sat inside the office of the prime minister of Bangladesh. For many supporters, the picture symbolised arrival after a long and uncertain journey.

A day earlier, Rahman had taken oath as the country's 11th PM. At 60, he steps into office from a life shaped as much by inheritance as by disruption. Born on November 20, 1965, in Dhaka—then part of East Pakistan—he is the elder son of Ziaur Rahman, the soldier-president assassinated in 1981, and Khaleda Zia, who later dominated national politics through two turbulent terms. Politics was never a distant calling; it arrived early, violently, and never quite receded. Yet, remarkably, 2026 marked the first time Rahman himself contested an election.

WHEN RAHMAN RETURNED TO DHAKA IN DECEMBER 2025 AFTER 17 YEARS IN SELF-IMPOSED EXILE, IT WAS LESS AS AN AVENGER THAN AS A SURVIVOR

Educated at some of Dhaka's most elite institutions, he briefly enrolled at the University of Dhaka to study law before switching to international relations. He did not complete his degree. Instead, in his early 20s, Rahman moved into business, establishing ventures in textiles and shipping. Supporters would later frame this period as evidence of managerial pragmatism; critics saw the beginnings of a backroom operator.

During Khaleda's second tenure (2001-06), Rahman had become indispensable within the Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP). He cultivated student leaders, strengthened grassroots networks and developed a reputation for decisiveness. Admirers hailed a modern political organiser; detractors warned of an instinct to centralise authority. When the BNP lost power and a military-backed caretaker government launched an anti-corruption drive, Rahman was arrested and charged in multiple cases involving graft and abuse of power. He has consistently alleged torture in custody and claimed there was an attempt to eliminate him. In 2008, he left Bangladesh for medical treatment—and remained away for 17 years.

London became both refuge and command centre. From there, alongside his physician wife, Dr Zubaida, and

INDIA PERCEIVED YUNUS'S ANTI-INDIA STATEMENTS AS UNDERMINING ITS STRATEGIC AND ECONOMIC ROLE IN THE REGION, PUSHING DHAKA TO BECOME PART OF CHINA'S BRI, TOWARD WHICH IT WAS VEERING

project Delhi as a co-conspirator in her alleged crimes (see box, *The Diplomatic Dilemma*). Hasina herself was convicted on multiple charges and sentenced to death by the International Crimes Tribunal, Bangladesh. India, though, repeatedly turned down Bangladesh's requests for her extradition, describing the trial indicting the former prime minister for serious crimes as unfair and conducted without due process of law. It only infuriated the interim dispensation further.

Yunus not only fanned anti-India sentiments in his country, but he also provoked India with gratuitous remarks, such as how the seven northeast Indian states were "landlocked", suggesting that only Bangladesh could be their gateway for economic connectivity to global markets. India perceived this as Yunus not only undermin-